Memo

To: Board of Education
From: Jon Franco, Senior Chief of Operations
Frank Leavitt, Sr. Director of Operations
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Brett Borgeson, Sr. Manager of EH&S
Date: November 16, 2026
Subject: Staff Response to the Community Proposed Indoor Air Quality (IAQ) Policy

Dear Board Members,

The District appreciates the thought and energy put into the proposed policy changes, however, the language from the Community Proposed Indoor Air Quality additions should not be attached to the existing Climate Crisis Response Policy. There are concerns that a blanket commitment to higher ventilation rates above ASHRAE 62.1 and the Oregon Mechanical Specialty Code would put the District in misalignment with the Climate Crisis Response Policy's energy and emissions targets. By consolidating this under one policy, we risk an expansion of the policy's scope that would dilute the existing language, (seeing a pivot from global emissions mitigation and climate action to localized public health) and implementation of the existing CCRP's climate goals.

If the Board decides that an Air Quality policy should exist, it should exist as a stand-alone policy, with the potential for a broader focus on public and environmental health. We recommend a collaborative staff-and-community-driven reporting structure, a timeline of goal implementation independent from the CCRPs timelines, and a clearly identified IAQ management team of existing staff members tasked with responding to the goals under the direction of a to-be-hired IAQ Coordinator position. The motivations behind this are to ultimately protect the current scope of the Climate Crisis Response Policy and to make the financial and operational impact of this proposed policy more apparent.

Core Policy Misalignment: Why IAQ & CCRP Should Remain Separate

The overarching objective of the CCRP is to mitigate global emissions and reduce our reliance on fossil fuels. Given IAQs focuses on micro-environmental public health parameters, targets like these would be better suited in a different policy with a focus on compliance with existing occupational health mandates. The combining of standard indoor occupational health mandates with global decarbonization policy dilutes the core focus of the CCRP and risks making it harder to reach net-zero by 2040.

In its current state, the CCRP explicitly states that district investments should prioritize those that achieve the "greatest emissions reduction." By elevating IAQ monitoring within the CCRP, the priority of the Climate Justice, Energy & Sustainability team would pivot from policy fulfillment to ongoing facilities operational maintenance, further hindering the pursuance of environmental and sustainability education gains as well as structural and multi-year carbon reduction projects. Additionally, the Climate Justice, Energy & Sustainability team has concerns about the lack of involvement of the Climate Crisis Response Committee in this policy decision.

The Climate Crisis Response Committee is a group of nine individuals (two students and seven adults), who are tasked with advising the PPS Board of Education on implementation of the CCRP. The committee has not been involved in this decision-making process or had the chance to formally provide input to the board on what they think about this

proposal. This proposed policy change would drastically alter the scope of what the CCRC oversees, without asking the individual committee members for their input on this decision. The CCRC's goal is to ensure the strength and relevance of the CCRP, and by not consulting them, they are not being utilized as the committee charter intends. This is another major driver in the desire for policy separation, establishing Air Quality as a standalone policy with a topical focus on public and environmental health.

Lastly, it is important to highlight that IAQ standards and HVAC operations are traditionally regulated under facilities management plans, standard operating procedures, occupational health and safety protocols (OSHA/ASHRAE), or public health guidelines. Many of these frameworks already inform the mission of the Environmental Health & Safety team in their pursuance of clean air in our schools. There is a hesitancy to lock in this level of detail in the Climate Crisis Response Policy, knowing that operational target metrics have the potential to rapidly evolve. As it stands, the CCRP has taken a more broad approach with its regulatory rigidity, so the Climate Justice, Energy & Sustainability team can adapt as the science and industry adapts. We believe any Air Quality targets should take the same approach with policy and take a more granular approach in the creation of operating procedures.

3rd-Party Technical Evaluation: Industry Expert Findings

Apex Companies is an environmental consulting firm that has been in business for 38 years and has a staff of almost 2,000 individuals, known for their technical excellence and commitment to quality. They were tasked with providing a report on the impact of changing the Ventilation Rates at Atkinson Elementary (chosen because it reflects an average Elementary School in terms of size within PPS). Schools in the District are built to industry standards using best practices, specifically compliance with legally adopted building codes. The emphasis on air changes per hour (ACH) in the proposed policy alone is not a widely-accepted industry benchmark for air ventilation systems.
The use of ASHRAE 62.1-2022 within the Oregon Mechanical Specialty Code represents the legally adopted, peer-reviewed, and balanced engineering standards for ventilation design. ASHRAE standards are developed through a multi-year consensus process involving engineers, public health experts, and regulators. It provides acceptable indoor air quality while maintaining reasonable construction costs, energy consumption, and environmental impact. Designing schools in compliance with OMSC and ASHRAE 62.1 therefore represents appropriate professional engineering practice and regulatory compliance.

Financial & Resource Constraints: Impact & Resource Allocation

Meeting aggressive ventilation goals like targeting 6 to 12 effective air changes per hour (ACH) requires running HVAC systems continuously and drawing in significantly larger volumes of unconditioned outdoor air. Increasing ventilation rates above codes and standards risks the longevity of our building systems and has the potential to overwork and ultimately increase the failure rate of building systems. Pursuing a target of 6 - 12 ACH would lead to ventilation rates at 50% to 200% higher than code minimums. Before a policy commitment of this caliber is made by this Committee, a larger conversation must happen, outside of the Climate Crisis Response Policy, to determine how existing Standard Operating Procedures and compliance with the CCRP can be balanced to meet additional goals.

The APEX report on ventilation rates to target 4 - 6 ACH suggests that we could see an annual increase of HVAC energy costs of $15,000-$30,000 at Atkinson Elementary. Pursuing rates of 6 - 12 ACH would see an even higher cost impact in our utility bill portfolio. Designing schools for higher ventilation rates requires larger mechanical equipment. Since HVAC systems typically represent 10% to 20% of total school construction cost, this translates to 1% to 5% increase in total building construction cost. In addition to the cost impact of pushing our air ventilation systems beyond existing standards and codes, we would see an increase to our HVAC's energy usage by 10-40% at each site, which will make

our emissions reduction targets harder to meet. Before adopting ventilations standards that are more robust than current ASHRAE 62.1 and OMSC recommendations, a larger conversation needs to happen around the conflict between pushing our building systems to work harder and the emissions that would accompany this policy decision.

The financial impacts of the proposed language are significant for the District. The proposed language would require the District to purchase sensors for each classroom at a (low end) cost of $1,500 per classroom. This cost does not include the hardwiring needed for each classroom from IT and Maintenance and the required maintenance and monitoring. With research from our HVAC partners, the estimated cost (low end) to increase air changes per hour (ACH) from 3 to 6 would be approximately $500,000 a year for the entire District. That is the basic operating costs of increased energy usage. This cost does not include the initial investment required by the District and the need for an additional FTE to monitor this program.

In conclusion, we recommend the following next steps:

- **Pause the Policy Adoption**: Do not include the IAQ additions into the CCRP to allow a more thorough board review of 3rd party findings.
- **Maintain CCRP Policy Boundaries**: Keep the Climate Crisis Response Policy focused on emissions reduction, net-zero goals, and structural climate action.
- **If establishing a Standalone Policy**: Draft a separate, dedicated IAQ policy supported by an IAQ Coordinator and tailored operational procedures and non-conflicting goals of CCRP.
- **Review Supporting Materials**
    - April 2026 FIOC Committee Air Quality Presentation
    - November 2026 Policy Committee Air Quality Presentation
    - November 2026 Air Quality Policy Staff Memo
    - Third-Party Evaluation Report (Apex) for Atkinson Elementary